AI Slop in Music:

A Review of the Literature on AI-Generated Content and 'Slop' in the Streaming Ecosystem

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Table of Contents

I. Introduction

II. Technological Background

III. Defining and Detecting "Slop"

IV. Platform Economics and Streaming Ecosystems

V. Regulatory and Policy Responses

VI. Gaps in the Literature

VII. Conclusion

References

I. Introduction

It is necessary to distinguish between “slop,” AI-assisted music, and AI-generated music. AI-generated music is entirely composed using AI tools. The tools can create melodies, harmonies, rhythms, and even entire songs based on predefined algorithms and training data. AI-assisted music is a process in which artists use AI as a tool to enhance their musical creativity rather than replacing it. This can look like AI algorithms providing suggestions regarding different music structures, styles, and genres. AI-powered platforms can also simulate ensemble performances and create new collaborative opportunities for students to interact with peers and musicians globally (Lin et al. 2024).

However, “slop” appears with clear patterns–large volumes of tracks are released in a short time frame, the artist identities are generic or vague, there is little to no verified social media presence, and the tracks are made specifically to land in background playlists. “Slop” differs from genuine creative work because its purpose is mass production and monetization. Streaming momentum typically begins on social media, allowing AI artists to go viral without an established identity (Neu, 2026).

This review asks the following guiding questions. How is AI slop defined or measured? What are its economic effects? How are musicians affected? How are platforms responding?

II. Technological Background

One of the top generative music tools, Suno, allows users to generate complete tracks with vocals, instrumentation, and production from a single text prompt describing a genre, mood, or idea. The platform offers a free tier, though free-tier songs are restricted to non-commercial use and remain Suno's property; commercial rights require a paid subscription (Suno, 2026). As of February 2026, Suno reported more than 100 million users and over 2 million paid subscribers, alongside $300 million in annual recurring revenue (Murray, 2026).

Similarly, Udio allows users to create tracks via text prompts, framing its platform as an opportunity for any user to express themselves through music by providing an idea (Udio, 2026). Its beta version was publicly released in April 2024. It was founded in December 2023 by four former Google DeepMind researchers (CEO David Ding, Conor Durkan, Charlie Nash, Yaroslav Ganin) under the name Uncharted Labs. It received backing from a16z, will.i.am, Common, Tay Keith, Steve Stoute’s UnitedMasters, Mike Krieger (co-founder and CTO of Instagram), Kevin Wall, the a16z Cultural Leadership Fund, and Oriol Vinyals (co-lead of Gemini), among many others, and was valued at $10 million in seed funding. The platform generates vocals and instrumentation from text prompts specifying genre, lyrics, and style influences, initially producing 30-second clips extendable in additional increments; paid subscribers access advanced features like audio inpainting (Hiatt, 2024).

Beyond Suno and Udio, large platform companies have launched mainstream, embedded music-generation tools. Google DeepMind's Lyria 3 model was rolled out in beta within the Gemini app

in February 2026 (Yawili & Hamed Torres, 2026), allowing users to generate 30-second tracks from text prompts or uploaded photos, with lyrics generated automatically rather than user-supplied. This signals a shift from standalone/niche AI-music startups toward integration into mass-adoption consumer apps (Gemini, YouTube Shorts), which is relevant to the "slop" framing because Google explicitly frames the tool's goal as fun, casual self-expression rather than "a musical masterpiece." This implicitly acknowledges that the product is optimized for volume/novelty over artistic merit. The same underlying model, Lyria 3, is also deployed on YouTube's Dream Track feature to generate Shorts soundtracks, illustrating how generative audio is being embedded directly into short-form content pipelines. Therefore, “slop” begins to saturate at a platform scale.

Generative music systems have evolved from earlier rule-based approaches, in which composers manually encoded compositional logic derived from music theory, into machine learning–based systems that instead learn statistical patterns from large datasets of existing music. Morreale et al. (2025) argue that this shift did not eliminate the reductive processes inherent to algorithmic composition: contemporary generative AI models still depend on a sequence of constraining choices, including which training data is accumulated, how raw audio is represented and tokenized, and how outputs are "conditioned" toward specific genres, moods, or styles.

In practice, most consumer-facing systems, such as Suno and Udio, operate as end-to-end text-to-music models, converting a user's prompt (describing genre, mood, lyrics, or a reference artist's style) into a complete track with vocals and instrumentation, typically generated first as a short segment and then extendable in additional increments (Hiatt, 2024; Suno, n.d.). Because these models rely on language, rather than musical parameters, as the primary interface for user intent, they require a "semantic bridge" between text and sound, a process Morreale et al. (2025) contend is inherently lossy, since language cannot fully capture music's non-propositional and pre-linguistic dimensions. This technical architecture has implications for the discourse on AI-generated "slop," as the same conditioning mechanisms that make these tools accessible to non-musicians may also constrain generated output toward homogenized, genre-typical patterns rather than genuinely novel musical structures.

III. Defining and Detecting "Slop"

Although the term saw a 334% increase in use in 2024 and was shortlisted for Oxford’s Word of the Year, “AI slop” lacked any formal academic definition until recently, with its coinage attributed to programmer Simon Willison in 2024 (Costa, 2025). Costa addresses this gap directly, providing an interdisciplinary account of the term.

Costa identifies four thematic dimensions via a thematic analysis of 34 sources cited on Wikipedia’s “AI slop” page:

- Efficiency and productivity: Slop is generated due to its low cost, speed, ease of creation, and scalability. This applies to corporations aiming to cut costs and individuals seeking side income.

These indicate a significant incoming shift in several industries, which is accompanied by concerns about the automation of creative labour.

- Danger and discernment: The excess of slop overwhelms information systems and creates the need for its filtering and moderation. This is especially challenging since slop does not strictly violate platform policies. This is threatening both to institutions and to individual users, which might unknowingly be exposed to false information.
- Epistemic crisis: Slop is related to moral anxieties about political disinformation, the “post-truth” environment, and the wider breakdown of shared reality and trust in institutions.
- Engagement economy: Platform incentives (such as engagement, virality, and ad revenue), which are ultimately about profit, are the primary drivers of slop. Individuals in low-income regions are especially incentivised to engage in its creation

Crucially, Costa argues that slop’s defining feature is not its artificial origin, but its poor quality. Alongside these thematic dimensions, Costa situates slop within the MIT AI Risk Repository’s taxonomy, under the subdomain “pollution of information ecosystem and loss of consensus reality.”

Costa reviews existing AI-content detection approaches (linguistic feature analysis, deep-learning classifiers like GPTZero and Pangram, fingerprint/pattern detection used by scientific-integrity tools) but argues it remains unclear whether slop detection is meaningfully different from general AI-content detection. Since slop is defined by low effort/quality rather than by artificial origin alone, a detector trained only to flag "AI-generated" would risk penalizing high-quality AI content, which is not the actual target. Costa's own empirical analysis (a dataset of 60,000 news articles, comparing "slop," human-written, and AI-generated text) found statistically significant but practically small differences: slop text shows slightly lower lexical variation/complexity and more uniformly positive sentiment than non-slop text, suggesting current linguistic-feature detection is only weakly discriminative.

Another attempt to characterize AI slop is the “7Vs” framework proposed by Madsen and Puyt (2025), which organizes the phenomenon along seven dimensions: volume (the sheer scale of content production), velocity (the speed at which content is generated and circulated), variety (the range of forms and genres slop takes), value (the erosion or transformation of cultural and epistemic worth), verification (the difficulty of establishing truth, trust, and provenance), visibility (the degree to which algorithmic systems amplify and surface the content), and virality (the meme-like, self-replicating diffusion of slop across platforms). Applied to music, this framework offers a more granular vocabulary than a single umbrella term: a platform's "volume" problem (e.g., Deezer's reported tens of thousands of daily AI-generated uploads) is analytically distinct from its "verification" problem (the difficulty of technically distinguishing AI vocals from human ones), even though both are commonly folded into the same colloquial complaint about "AI slop."

IV. Platform Economics and Streaming Ecosystems

Platform responses to AI-generated music range from outright bans to disclosure requirements to permissive non-intervention. On the restrictive end, Bandcamp prohibits music "generated wholly or in substantial part by AI," including AI tools used to impersonate other artists' styles, though enforcement relies on user reporting rather than automated detection (Bandcamp, 2026). SoundCloud similarly bars

monetization of any track that is "exclusively (100% GenAI) computer-generated," while iHeartRadio adopted a company-wide "Guaranteed Human" policy banning AI-generated music and synthetic on-air personalities across its radio and podcast network (Billboard, 2025; LA Times, 2025).

A second group of platforms permits AI-generated music but requires disclosure. Apple Music introduced an optional AI-transparency tag allowing distributors to flag AI involvement at the composition, video, or track level. However, the platform does not define a threshold for how much AI use triggers disclosure (Billboard, 2026). TikTok requires creators to disclose AI-generated vocals or likenesses through labels or hashtags and prohibits using a real person's voice to create a false impression of their participation, and has partnered with the Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA) to implement content-credential labeling (TikTok Newsroom, 2026). Spotify's most recent policy update (September 2025, expanded April 2026) is the most comprehensive: it introduced stricter rules against unauthorized vocal cloning, a spam filter aimed at mass AI uploads and "artificially short tracks" designed to divert streaming royalties, and a DDEX-based industry standard allowing labels to disclose specific AI contributions (vocals, instrumentation, post-production) in track credits. Spotify explicitly frames its concern around "content farms" using AI to "mass-produce large volumes of low-effort tracks ('slop')" that confuse listeners and divert royalties. It has since launched a "Verified by Spotify" badge intended to help distinguish human artists (Spotify Newsroom, 2025, 2026).

A third group has no clear public policy and effectively permits AI-generated content by default. Amazon Music allows AI-generated tracks through standard distribution pipelines with no disclosure requirement or detection system, despite simultaneously promoting an Alexa–Suno integration and partnering with Universal Music Group to address "unlawful AI-generated content." Anghami has taken an actively pro-AI stance, offering AI-generated podcasts and music features directly to users. Pandora likewise has no stated policy, and user complaints on Pandora's own community forums have called for a mechanism to report or label AI-generated ("slop") tracks (Pandora Community, n.d.).

The clearest evidence that AI-generated music intersects with outright fraud, rather than merely aesthetic degradation, comes from the first criminal prosecution of its kind in the United States. In September 2024, federal prosecutors indicted Michael Smith, a North Carolina musician, for using AI to generate hundreds of thousands of songs and then deploying networks of up to 10,000 bot accounts to stream them billions of times, fraudulently obtaining more than $10 million in royalties over a seven-year scheme (U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of New York, 2024). Smith pleaded guilty in March 2026 to conspiracy to commit wire fraud and agreed to forfeit over $8 million (U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of New York, 2026). The case is significant not only for its scale but for what it reveals about the underlying mechanism. Nearly every major streaming platform pays royalties through a pro-rata pool–dividing total subscription and ad revenue proportionally by each track's share of total streams–every fraudulent stream directly reduces the payout available to legitimately streamed artists, meaning the harm is diffused across the entire platform's artist base rather than concentrated in a single victim (U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of New York, 2024).

This dynamic has since scaled well beyond a single bad actor. Deezer's proprietary AI-detection system found that fully AI-generated tracks accounted for a rapidly rising share of daily uploads–climbing from roughly 10,000 per day in 2025 to 75,000 by April 2026–and reported that as much as 85% of streams on fully AI-generated tracks were fraudulent rather than genuine listening activity (Pophits, 2026). Apple

Music similarly disclosed flagging roughly two billion fraudulent streams in 2025, representing an estimated $17 million in royalties that would otherwise have been misallocated (Revolution 935, 2026).

V. Regulatory and Policy Responses

In January 2026, U.S. Representatives Madeleine Dean and Nathaniel Moran introduced the Transparency and Responsibility for Artificial Intelligence Networks Act ("TRAIN Act"), a bill that would grant copyright holders a new mechanism to investigate whether their work was used without permission to train AI systems (Chen, 2026). Rather than requiring a copyright holder to file a lawsuit and go through full discovery, the bill would let them request a subpoena directly from a federal court clerk by certifying a "good-faith belief" that their copyrighted material was used in training data. If passed, the bill would require AI developers to maintain detailed, traceable records of their training data pipelines, from initial collection through annotation and model training, substantially raising compliance costs and potentially pushing companies toward licensed datasets or data-provenance tracking tools rather than the loosely sourced data scraping practiced today. For copyright holders and the music industry more broadly, the bill's main appeal is bargaining leverage: by making it easier to obtain concrete evidence that a company used copyrighted material, it would strengthen creators' negotiating position when seeking licensing deals with AI companies, and could support the growth of structured licensing markets (Chen, 2026).

The bill's prospects remain uncertain. It runs counter to the Trump administration's deregulatory approach to AI policy, including a December 2025 executive order emphasizing that AI companies must be able to innovate without "cumbersome regulation," which raises the possibility of a presidential veto even if the bill passes Congress. Still, Chen (2026) argues the bill is not without effect regardless of its ultimate fate: its introduction has already elevated the issue of AI training-data transparency in national policy debate, and may itself pressure AI companies toward more cautious data practices even without formal enactment.

Additionally, the Nurture Originals, Foster Art, and Keep Entertainment Safe Act (“NO FAKES Act”) protects the voice and visual likeness of all individuals from unauthorized computer-generated recreations from generative AI. The NO FAKES Act would address the use of non-consensual digital replications holding individuals or companies liable if they produce an unauthorized digital replica of an individual in a performance, holding platforms liable for hosting an unauthorized digital replica if the platform has actual knowledge of the fact that the replica was not authorized by the individual depicted, excluding certain digital replicas from coverage based on recognized First Amendment protections, and largely preempt State laws addressing digital replicas to create a workable national standard (Office of Senator Chris Coons, 2026). The act was introduced in May 2026, and was placed on the Senate Legislative Calendar under General Orders in June 2026.

VI. Gaps in the Literature

AI slop literature identifies several unresolved measurement problems directly relevant to future research on music slop. Weedon et al. (2026), distinguish between “first-order” harms (ex., a single fraudulent track or scam) and “second-order” harms (ex., royalty dilution, labor market displacement for musicians, or erosion of listener trust in streaming platforms). This report argues that researchers lack shared baselines for measuring these second-order effects, partially because platforms restrict the data access needed to identify inflection points or isolate slop’s contributions.

Another concern is whether disclosure and labeling requirements actually address the underlying harms motivating them. Gallegos et al. (2025) found that disclosing AI origin changes audiences’ beliefs about the creation of a piece of content, but does not change how persuasive or engaging they find it. If this finding generalizes to music, it would suggest that AI-disclosure tags may satisfy transparency goals without meaningfully addressing the harms that motivated their adoption in the first place.

VII. Conclusion

The literature on AI slop in music remains scattered across various sources, but there are a few key takeaways to note. First, “slop” resists a single definition–reviewed sources locate it variously in content quality (Costa, 2026), production incentives (Weedon et al., 2026), and the question of labor (Hiatt, 2024). Second, the economic stakes are structural. Streaming platforms are not neutral arbiters of AI music, but they have a financial incentive to favor royalty-free synthetic content. Third, technical detection remains immature.

Many gaps appear in measurement: there is no music-specific equivalent of Costa’s analysis of slop text, no empirical study testing whether AI-disclosure labels change listener behavior in a streaming context, and no reliable data on how AI-generated volume displaces human-made music in recommendation systems, largely due to platforms' restricted data access.

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